DM guide – building a combat encounter · SRD 5.2.1

To build an encounter, you choose a **difficulty** (Low, Moderate or High) and compute an **XP budget**: table value per character × number of characters. You spend that budget adding **creatures** by their XP value.

Avoid more than about **two creatures per character**, especially at levels 1 and 2, and be careful with creatures whose CR exceeds the party's level.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Choose: **Low**, **Moderate** or **High**.
2. Budget = table value × number of characters.
3. Spend the budget on creature XP, without exceeding it.
4. About **2 creatures** per character at most.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 replaces the 2014 "group multiplier" with an XP budget per character by three difficulty levels.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The budget includes neither terrain nor remaining resources. Fix: adjust to the party's state and the setting.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe creatures arriving in waves so the budget is spread over time.

Step 1 – Choose the difficulty:

Low: nearly risk-free. Moderate: risk of losses. High: potentially lethal.

Step 2 – Compute the budget:

Table value × number of characters.

Step 3 – Spend:

Add creatures (see the XP-by-CR table) without exceeding the budget.

Step 4 – Check:

No more than two creatures per character; no CR too high.

Step 5 – Adjust in play:

Remove creatures or add reinforcements as the fight unfolds.

Example: 4 level 3 characters, Moderate: 225 × 4 = 900 XP. For instance 2 CR 1 creatures (200 each) + 4 CR 1/4 creatures (50 each) = 600, or one CR 3 monster (700).

COMBAT ENCOUNTERS (5E, 2024 RULES) – XP BUDGET

XP budget per character

Level	Low	Moderate	High
1	50	75	100
2	100	150	200
3	150	225	400
4	250	375	500
5	500	750	1,100
6	600	1,000	1,400
7	750	1,300	1,700
8	1,000	1,700	2,100
9	1,300	2,000	2,600
10	1,600	2,300	3,100
11	1,900	2,900	4,100
12	2,200	3,700	4,700
13	2,600	4,200	5,400
14	2,900	4,900	6,200
15	3,300	5,400	7,800
16	3,800	6,100	9,800
17	4,500	7,200	11,700
18	5,000	8,700	14,200
19	5,500	10,700	17,200
20	6,400	13,200	22,000

XP by CR (excerpt)

CR	0	1/8	1/4	1/2	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
XP	0–10	25	50	100	200	450	700	1,100	1,800	2,300	2,900	3,900	5,000	5,900

⚠ Common questions:

How do I compute?

Table value × number of characters.

Can I exceed it?

You may stay under; don't exceed.

How many creatures?

About 2 per character at most.

What about swarms?

Use swarms rather than many 0-XP creatures.

CR above level?

Handle carefully: can drop a character fast.

A player is absent?

Remove creatures during play.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Budget and resources

The party is low on resources. **Option**: lower the difficulty one step.

Multiple encounters

Several fights in a day. **Option**: split the budget.

Boss and minions

A boss + minions. **Option**: bigger boss budget.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Difficulty

Low, Moderate, High: three risk tiers.

Budget

It's computed per character, not per party.

Creature XP

Each creature has an XP value by CR.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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